CESIF
Centre for Social Innovation and Foreign Policy

Bodhi Sambad

BODHI SAMBAD 2026

An international Conference on 'China in South Asia'

Proposed Date: 21-23 May 2026 (TBC)
Duration: 3-4 days
Location: Kathmandu, Nepal

Context

The increasing presence of China in South Asia has fundamentally changed the geopolitical, economic, security and strategic landscape of the region. As Beijing expands its multi-layered economic, political, and security engagements across the region through initiatives like the Belt and Road, it is reshaping the traditional regional power dynamics, connectivity patterns, economic and trade partnerships. While Chinese investments have funded major infrastructure projects, they have also raised concerns about unsustainable debt burdens and strategic encirclement. Lately, China has sought to influence domestic processes, whether it is shaping public opinion, influencing policies, or encouraging new development and governance models, and the support for governments undergoing democratic decline.

Beijing has employed a multi-faceted approach to expand its influence in South Asia, focusing on economic partnerships, security cooperation and political ties. Its security and defense strategies include arms sales and defense equipment transfers to countries like Pakistan and Bangladesh, joint military exercises, and construction of dual-use infrastructure such as ports[1]. Politically, China has cultivated close relationships through high-level diplomatic visits, support for friendly factions, and use of economic leverage to influence decision-making[2].China has also employed soft power tactics to increase its influence. China has been promoting Mandarin language learning and offering scholarships to South Asian students. It has been aggressively pursuing Buddhist diplomacy, particularly with Sri Lanka and Nepal, guided by its larger strategy to

[1] https://foreignaffairs.house.gov/china-snapshot-project-south-asia/
[2] https://thediplomat.com/2024/05/jabin-jacob-on-chinas-growing-influence-in-south-asia/

co-opt Buddhism across South and South East Asia. Further, expanding cultural exchanges and promotion of Chinese cuisine, entertainment and sports is gradually shaping Chinese dominance across the region[3].

Rationale For the Conference

Fragmented mechanisms exist for South Asian countries to realize and analyze their interactions with China, impeding the development of a comprehensive regional understanding. Individual South Asian countries often examine China's engagement through narrow bilateral lenses, missing the broader regional patterns and implications. Current research and policy discourse lack the comprehensive regional perspective necessary to address shared challenges and opportunities that transcend national boundaries.

Addressing these limitations through collectively generating knowledge and increased dialogue could help countries develop more nuanced approaches to engaging with China, potentially strengthening their bargaining positions.

Aims and Objectives

The high-level 3-4 day conference is aimed to promote as a regional hub for dialogue on China-South Asia relations. It aims to bring together policymakers, think tanks, activists, scholars based in South Asia or other countries— monitoring and analyzing China's growing engagements in the region to discuss trends, patterns, scale and influence of Chinese engagements on South Asia's security, political, economic and cultural sphere.

The conference also aims to facilitate informed discussion on growing India-China geopolitical rivalry in the region and its implications for non-nuclear small states in the neighbourhood, and how China-India rise; alongside engagement of other countries within the framework of broader Indo-Pacific Strategy would impact the region stability and strategic choices of South Asian states.

Conference Format and Activities

Phase I

Initially CESIF will convene a regional working group of think tanks across South Asian countries, particularly from Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Myanmar. The CESIF team will conduct

[3] https://kathmandupost.com/columns/2023/12/20/china-s-growing-footprint-in-south-asia

an initial strategy meeting among the members of the working group to develop consensus on priority areas of each countries regarding China's engagements, including the themes, session topics and experts, and the ways to leverage the conference to identify potential areas of collaboration, and develop collective response and further roadmap.

Phase II

In advance of the main international conference in kathmandu, CESIF in collaboration with working group partners will organize a virtual dialogue among the group and other invited regional stakeholders from each countries, including the academia, media, civil society and governments to hold extensive discussion on country-specific CCP engagements and offer space for comparative analysis of response. The country specific presentations (and a panel discussion) will foster cross-country learning and form a basis for the design of international conference.

Phase III

The main international conference will be held in Kathmandu on May 2026. Apart from experts and members of the working group from South Asia, the event is expected to host experts working on China studies and familiar with China's engagements in South Asia, from South East Asia, Europe, Australia, US, UK, Japan, Singapore and other countries.

The conference will host 1 or 2 (TBD) members of the think tanks of the regional working group as panelists/speakers. CESIF will bear all the cost for travel and accomodation for the invited delegates. The conference is expected to be a three day event (the first two days focused on China in South Asia theme). The conference will feature country specific presentations and atleast 10 panel discussions on identified themes. Some closed door roundtables on critical issues will be organized apart from the panel discussion. Some on-call meeting with high level Nepali government officials will also be planned for the delegates.

Potential Themes for the Conference

The conference will center upon China's multifaceted engagements in South Asia and the wider region, and its implications for democratic resilience and strategic autonomy for South Asian countries. The themes of the discussion would also include how China's rise is unfolding contestation with the traditional powers in the region and devise strategic choices for the South Asian countries to navigate this unfolding geopolitical realities.

Some potential themes for the conference-

- The Great Power Rivalry in South Asia- Strategic dilemma for small states

- China's peripheral diplomacy- Shifting patterns of cross-border ties
- BRI in South Asia: Enthusiasm to Skepticism
- China's influence on Governance, politics and institutions (Political Influence and Democratic Resilience)
- Economic Engagements: Debt, Transparency, and Sovereignty
- Information warfare and disinformation campaigns: Raising threat for South Asia
- Soft power, cultural influence and civilizational narratives- A new Dependency?
- Shifting security landscape in South Asia: Navigating China' security and defence engagements

(The themes presented here are indicative and should be tailored and improvised further after stakeholder consultations and participants profile)

Target participants

- Members of the South Asian think tanks actively involved in researching and analyzing China's engagement and influence in South Asian countries
- Scholars specializing in Chinese foreign policy, economics, security, and soft power, from universities and research institutions globally
- Researchers focusing on information manipulation, propaganda, and media influence, particularly in the context of state-sponsored campaigns
- Advocacy groups focused on democratic norms and civic space in South Asia
- Reporters and editors from mainstream and independent media outlets across South Asia and beyond, particularly those covering foreign affairs, economic development, and geopolitical issues in South Asia and Indo-Pacific region
- Government Officials, Policy makers, security officials, diplomats and civil society members involved in bilateral and regional relations with China, as well as those shaping Indo-Pacific strategies
- Representatives from industries involved in trade, investment, and infrastructure projects with China, offering insights into economic realities and challenges.

Expected Outcomes

The overarching goal of the conference is to deepen the intellectual understanding of China's influence in South Asia through meticulous discussion among the concerned stakeholders and devise policy option to effectively deal with Chinese foothold to foster a resilient, prosperous and strategically autonomous South Asia.

In particular, the conference is expected to enhance the regional understanding and shared perspectives on China's role in South Asia beyond the individual national viewpoints, and foster the collective bargaining positions in engagements with China for common benefit.

Furthermore, the conference would maximize the collaborative efforts of South Asian think tanks and enhance their capacity to derive policy recommendations through unified and informed approach.

For Further Queries-

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